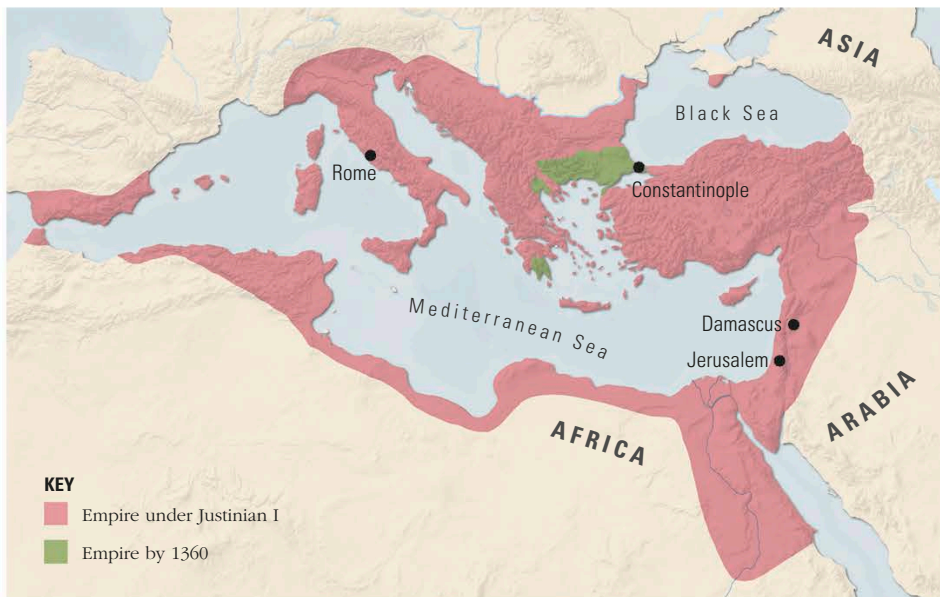




▲ RISE AND FALL OF THE EMPIRE

In the 6th century, the empire stretched around most of the Mediterranean Sea, but it lost important territory, such as the lands of Egypt and Syria, to Muslim armies soon after. By 1360, it had shrunk considerably, and it continued to lose territory until it collapsed entirely in 1453.

EASTERN ORTHODOX CHURCH ►

The Roman Catholic and Eastern Orthodox Churches disagreed on how they understood Christianity and worshipped God. The Orthodox Church did not recognize the authority of the Pope. These differences grew over the centuries, leading the two Churches to formally part ways in 1054.



The third slanted crossbeam makes this instantly recognizable as an Orthodox cross.

▼ HAGIA SOPHIA

Built as a Christian church, the Hagia Sophia (meaning "Divine Wisdom") was completed in 537 CE. After Constantinople fell to the Ottomans in 1453, it was turned into a mosque. The building's architecture reflects a mix of both Christian and Islamic influences.

The dome represents heaven and the afterlife. It was the largest dome in the world until the 15th century.

Islamic minarets were added in the 15th and 16th centuries.



MAJOR EVENTS

306–337

Constantine I becomes the first emperor of the Eastern Roman Empire. He establishes a new eastern capital, Constantinople, named after himself.

527–565

Justinian I comes to power and reconquers some of the land lost after the fall of the Western Roman Empire. This includes parts of Africa, Italy, and Spain.

600–900

The first coins to depict Jesus Christ are minted during the reign of Justinian II. The design of Christ with long hair and a beard became standard for all future coins.



GOLD COIN SHOWING CHRIST

976–1025

The reign of Basil II begins a golden age for the empire. Under his rule, the empire becomes wealthier and extends its territory into the Balkans and beyond.

1071

Conflicts between the Byzantine and the Seljuk empires lead to the Battle of Manzikert. The Seljuks win, weakening Byzantine power in Anatolia (part of modern-day Turkey).

1095–1204

Roman Catholic armies attempt to recapture Jerusalem during the Crusades. During the Fourth Crusade (1202–1204), they attack and ransack Constantinople.

1204–1453

Weakened from constant invasions, Constantinople is reduced to a city-state, and falls to the Ottomans in 1453.